Etiquette when Requesting a Letter of Recommendation

Whether it be for further graduate study, the workforce, internships or fellowships, Cal Poly staff are prepared and excited to usher students into the next phase of their professional life with recommendations and references. This process requires students to be intentional about building relationships, timely in their requests, and providing staff with the tools.

Here is a guide on developing professional relationships with staff and requesting recommendations in a mindful, respectful, and effective manner.

Building Relationships

You want to choose staff that can speak to your qualities as a student. Professors have hundreds of students so if you know what professor you'd like a letter or reference from at some point, build a relationship early on to stand out. The better our staff get to know you the more thorough a letter they can write about you.

- Consistently attend office hours, email questions, and chat before/after class
- Take more than one of their classes, and if you can't, stay connected with them
- Get involved! Research, events, clubs, organizations, internships, volunteer
- Be attentive, present, and participatory in the classroom

Who to Choose and How to Ask

Choose staff that know you well, know your work, and identify what function your recommender should have. Who can write the best recommendation for you for this particular opportunity?

Once you choose someone and are ready to ask, be mindful of the fact that staff can decline to write you a letter if they feel they don't know you well enough or

for any reason. It is up to their discretion but it's not something to take personally. It is better for them to decline than to write you a letter that doesn't honor you.

It is best to ask, **"Do you feel you know me well enough to write a letter of recommendation for me?"**. Rather than saying, "Will you write me a recommendation?" asking if they feel comfortable writing, one is a better approach and gives them a way out if they don't.

Timeliness

Asking in a timely manner is imperative; Cal Poly staff are busy, especially around the time of the year you'd likely be asking for a letter. Ideally, give the person four weeks but never less than two weeks. It's best to run it by them a few months before the application is due and follow up/ provide information four weeks ahead. Earlier is always better! A rushed letter of recommendation may not be as positive or polished. To ensure your recommendation is completed on time:

- You can give your recommender an earlier deadline than the program or job deadline
- Follow up one week before it's due either in person or through email to check in and see if they need any additional information from you
- Ask to be notified by email when the letter has been sent

Provide Information

Whether you built a relationship with your recommender or not, you will need to provide them with information for an effective recommendation. You should provide information about the opportunity you are applying for and information about yourself as a professional. You want to give your recommender the tools to adjust their recommendation in a way that serves your specific application and highlights relevant personal qualities.

<u>About You</u>

- An up-to-date resume

- Most recent transcript
- Your personal statement or cover letter that you wrote for the opportunity or write a brief statement discussing why you are interested in this opportunity and how it fits your professional goals
- A reason why you are asking this specific staff member for a recommendation, as well as who will be writing your other recommendations

<u>About the position/program</u>

- The name and a brief description of the opportunity you are applying for
- If known, the name and title of the person who will receive the letter
- The address or website
- The date you need the recommendation by and the way in which you'd like it given (Email, in person pick up, mailed, faxed, online submission etc.)
    - If mailed, provide an envelope with the address and a stamp

Be Gracious

Always reach out to your recommender to say Thank you if not in person, through email or a handwritten note. This acknowledges the time you asked them for, maintains a positive relationship, and makes them more inclined to write you another recommendation if asked again.

Keep your recommender updated on the positive results of the job, internship, school, etc. that you applied for. It is nice to let staff know that their efforts were fruitful.